

Set-Pieces in Football: A Guide to Standard Situations

When watching a football match, you might hear commentators emphasize the importance of **set-pieces**, often stating that a team "must capitalize on their set-piece opportunities." But what exactly does this mean? How many different types of set-pieces exist, and when do they occur?

What Are Set-Pieces in Football?

The term **set-piece** (or "standard situation") was first used in **East German football training** during the 1970s. It referred to **specific match situations that players should know instinctively**, as they occur frequently in games.

Following German reunification, the term gradually made its way into **West German football**, where it was adopted by **coaches, commentators, and journalists**.

In simple terms, **set-pieces refer to all restarts of play following a stoppage**.

Types of Set-Pieces in Football

There are **seven major types of set-pieces**, each playing a crucial role in match strategy and execution.

1. Kick-Off

The match starts with a **kick-off** at the **beginning of each half** and **after every goal**.

A coin toss decides which team kicks off the **first half**, while the opposing team gets the **second-half kick-off**.

The ball is placed on the **center spot**, and all players (except the kicker) must be in their own half.

Opponents must maintain a **9.15-meter distance** until the ball is in play.

The kicker **cannot touch the ball again** until another player has made contact.

2. Free-Kick

A **free-kick** is awarded for **fouls, handballs, or unsporting behavior**.

Direct free-kick: The taker can shoot **directly at goal**.

Indirect free-kick: The ball **must touch another player** before a goal can be scored.

- ♦ Defensive walls must be at least **9.15 meters away** from the ball.
- ♦ Free-kicks can be taken **quickly** unless the referee requires a delay (e.g., for a booking).

3. Corner Kick

A **corner kick** occurs when a **defender last touches the ball before it crosses their own goal line (without a goal being scored)**.

The ball is placed **inside the quarter-circle** at the nearest corner flag.

Defenders must maintain a **9.15-meter distance**.

The kicker **cannot touch the ball twice consecutively**.

Corners are one of the **most dangerous attacking set-pieces**, often leading to goals.

4. Throw-In

A **throw-in** is awarded when the ball fully crosses a **sideline**.

The team that **did not last touch the ball** takes the throw.

The thrower must:

- ✓ Stand **outside the pitch** with at least one foot touching the touchline.
- ✓ Use **both hands** to throw the ball **overhead**.

A throw-in cannot lead **directly to a goal**.

5. Goal Kick

A **goal kick** is awarded when the attacking team **kicks the ball over the opponent's goal line without scoring**.

The ball is placed **inside the penalty area** and can be taken by **any defensive player** (usually the goalkeeper).

Opposing players **must remain outside the penalty area** until the ball is in play.

Since **2019**, the ball is in play **as soon as it is kicked**, even if opponents are inside the penalty area.

6. Penalty Kick

A **penalty kick** is awarded when a **defender commits a foul inside their own penalty area**.

The ball is placed **on the penalty spot (11 meters from goal)**.

Only the **kicker and goalkeeper** are allowed inside the box.

All other players must be at least **9.15 meters away**.

If the goalkeeper **saves the shot**, the ball remains in play.

Penalties are among the **most high-pressure moments** in football.

7. Dropped Ball (Referee Ball)

A **dropped ball** is used when play is stopped for reasons **not related to fouls or rule violations** (e.g., injuries, external interference).

Before **2019**, a dropped ball was a **contested situation**, where players could fight for possession.

Since **2019**, the ball is given **exclusively to the team that last had possession**, with opponents staying **at least four meters away**.

If the ball was in the **penalty area**, the **goalkeeper receives the restart**.

Why Are Set-Pieces So Important?

✓ **Many goals originate from set-pieces**—especially in tight, defensively structured matches.

✓ **Teams specialize in set-piece strategies**, with rehearsed plays for free-kicks and corners.

✓ **Well-drilled teams** can use set-pieces to their advantage, even against stronger opponents.

Understanding **set-pieces** helps fans appreciate the **tactical depth** of football and why they can **change the course of a match**.